

The Psychology of Gollum: A Two-Agent Bargaining Model of the Self

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The clinical literature treats Gollum as a cautionary tale about addiction. This is correct but incomplete. What the record actually documents — in unusual detail, thanks to two attentive hobbit observers — is a *bargaining game between two selves sharing one body*, and it rewards formal treatment.

1 The setup

Model the individual as two agents. **Sméagol** has conventional preferences: food, memory of sunlight, the approval of others. **Gollum** has a single dominant preference with an infinite reservation price. The two alternate control of the body — the observable “arguments” are, in this reading, negotiation rounds over the allocation of future control.

The Ring functions as an *asymmetric commitment device*: every period it strengthens Gollum’s bargaining position and erodes Sméagol’s outside option. After five hundred years, Sméagol’s threat point is approximately zero. That he negotiates anything at all is remarkable.

2 The Frodo intervention

The most interesting event in the dataset is exogenous: Frodo extends trust, addresses Sméagol by name, and — critically — creates *external* value for the Sméagol identity. For a period, the equilibrium visibly shifts: service is rendered, promises are kept, the Gollum agent is suppressed in daylight hours.

The mechanism matters for policy. Frodo did not strengthen Sméagol’s willpower (an intra-personal resource); he changed the *payoff structure* by making cooperation externally rewarded. Recovery, in this model, is not a triumph of will but a renegotiation under improved outside options.

3 The relapse, and the stairs of Cirith Ungol

The equilibrium collapses on contact with a third party who assigns the Sméagol identity zero value. One act of misrecognition — Sam’s accusation over the innocent matter of the rabbits — reprices Sméagol’s cooperative strategy to worthless, and Gollum resumes control permanently. Practitioners will recognise the pattern: the relapse is triggered not by the addictive good but by the withdrawal of the identity that made abstention worthwhile.

4 Implication

If the self is a coalition, treatment is coalition management. Punishing the whole individual strengthens precisely the agent you wish to weaken — a result this author has verified, at length, in committee.